suffering fools gladly nor believing his opponents were not fools (or knaves). Acheson became one of the wise men of US statecraft and advised successive Democrat presidents. He played various roles over Berlin and Cuba during the Kennedy administration and was a voice in the President's ear during the missile crisis. Irritatingly, none of Acheson's contributions, including his one-on-one talks with Kennedy, were recorded. Acheson himself supported a surgical strike on the missiles (which was JFK's original preference), but did not favour large-scale bombardment or invasion. He was a very different species of hawk to LeMay.

President Kennedy chose a different path to the one proposed by Acheson, who was unhappy at this. In 1969 he wrote a curmudgeonly response to Robert Kennedy's *Thirteen Days*, subsequently described as 'homage to plain dumb luck'.[47] Acheson nevertheless raised what is now recognised as a vital factor in the outcome of the crisis.

Robert McNamara later emerged as the principal proponent of the idea that luck was the most important factor in the crisis. The former Defense Secretary argued that the crisis was 'the best managed crisis of the last half of the century, but we were very lucky as well.' In fact, this view was not far from Acheson's assessment:

> It was not enough, Napoleon observed, that he should have good generals; he wanted them to be lucky generals, also. In foreign affairs brains, preparation, judgment, and power are of upmost importance, but luck is essential. It does not detract from President Kennedy's laurels in handling the Cuban crisis that he was helped by the luck of Khrushchev's befuddlement and loss of nerve. The fact was that he succeeded. However, as the Duke of Wellington said of Waterloo, it was 'a damned near thing.' And one should not play one's luck so far too often.[48]

Acheson's last point very much accorded with McNamara's concerns about nuclear weapons.

Over the decades in which McNamara immersed himself in studying the crisis, his reflections developed, and his emphasis on the importance of luck